

County wants to feather nest for waterfowl

Bond issue proposed to buy refuge land

By DIANNE WHITACRE
Staff Writer

If voters approve \$5.6 million in park and recreation bonds to buy the Cowan's Ford Waterfowl Refuge, don't look for any soccer fields or tennis courts. Look for Canada geese, teal and mallard.

The waterfront refuge near Mountain Island Lake would stay a refuge and won't become another park, county parks Director Wayne Weston said.

A few more waterfowl viewing platforms may be built on high ground and some parking added.

But otherwise, if the county buys the land from Duke Power's Crescent Resources, the refuge will stay the way it is, Weston said.

"It's a very sensitive area, much more sensitive than McDowell Park," a nature preserve the county operates at the opposite end of the county. McDowell, with its paddleboats, vending machines and hiking trails, is one of the county's most popular parks. Cowan's Ford will be reserved for waterfowl and will not be a park, Weston said.

The Mecklenburg Board of County Commissioners has unoffi-

Possible purchase: County commissioners hope to buy the Cowan's Ford Waterfowl Refuge, as a

way of preserving land around Mountain Island Lake and protecting the area's drinking water.

cially agreed to ask voters to approve \$5.6 million in bonds to buy about 800 acres from Crescent Resources. The land at the end of Neck Road is part of the Mountain Island Lake watershed, which provides drinking water to 400,000 people.

Commissioners, who will make final decisions on the bonds in August, have said they are committed to protecting the area's water supply by restricting development around the lake. This would be their first land purchase for that purpose.

Park bond issues have been overwhelmingly approved by Mecklenburg County voters. In 1986, park bonds passed with 63.7% approving and in 1989, 61.9%.

Selling voters on the idea of paying taxes to pay for land few of them probably will ever visit may be more difficult than bonds to pay for softball fields, Weston said. "Some people won't understand what you are trying to do. We have to aim at the future generations."

Mary McDaniel, founder of the Mountain Island Lake Conservancy, admits to "having mixed feelings" about the county parks department operating a waterfowl refuge, but after many talks with Weston she is confident that little will be done to the land. The conservancy wants to protect the purity of the lake by asking the county to buy the surrounding land before developers build houses or shopping centers on it.

"We want to keep it a very low-impact area — not a lot of trails and people tromping around the habitat," McDaniel said.

Better access would help school



McDaniel

Weston

groups and bird watchers enjoy the refuge, she said, but much of the refuge should remain off limits so ducks and geese won't be harassed.

McDaniel believes public ownership of the land is critical to protecting the area's drinking water. "Crescent has no big push to develop the land right now, but they have made it clear they couldn't continue to get no revenue for it."

The N.C. Wildlife Resources Commission leases the 1,000-acre refuge from Crescent for \$400 a year. The state maintains the property and, in turn, leases a portion of the land to a Mecklenburg farmer who plants corn and wheat that feed the geese in fall and winter.

"He gets the wheat in the spring, and the geese get it in the fall. Everybody benefits," said Richard Allison, president of Catawba Waterfowl Inc., the nonprofit group that started the Cowan's Ford Waterfowl Refuge about 1960.

Local hunters organized the refuge on leased Duke Power land, across from the utility's River Bend Steam Plant. "They didn't hunt there, but hoped to (hunt) outside

the refuge," said Allison, who lives nearby.

"Dr. Rufus Hoover and some other hunters wanted a place to attract waterfowl, so they set it up," Allison said. Hoover was Allison's dentist and he, too, joined the group in 1962.

"They didn't attract them (ducks) the way they wanted to," and over the years, many of the hunters have dropped out and have been replaced with conservationists.

About 125 members pay \$10 a year to belong. Most of the money goes to pay for postage. The state maintains the land, which attracts up to 400 geese in the fall. From 25 to 100 live there year-round, said Allison, whose grandfather, Richard M. Allison, ran a ferry across the Catawba River.

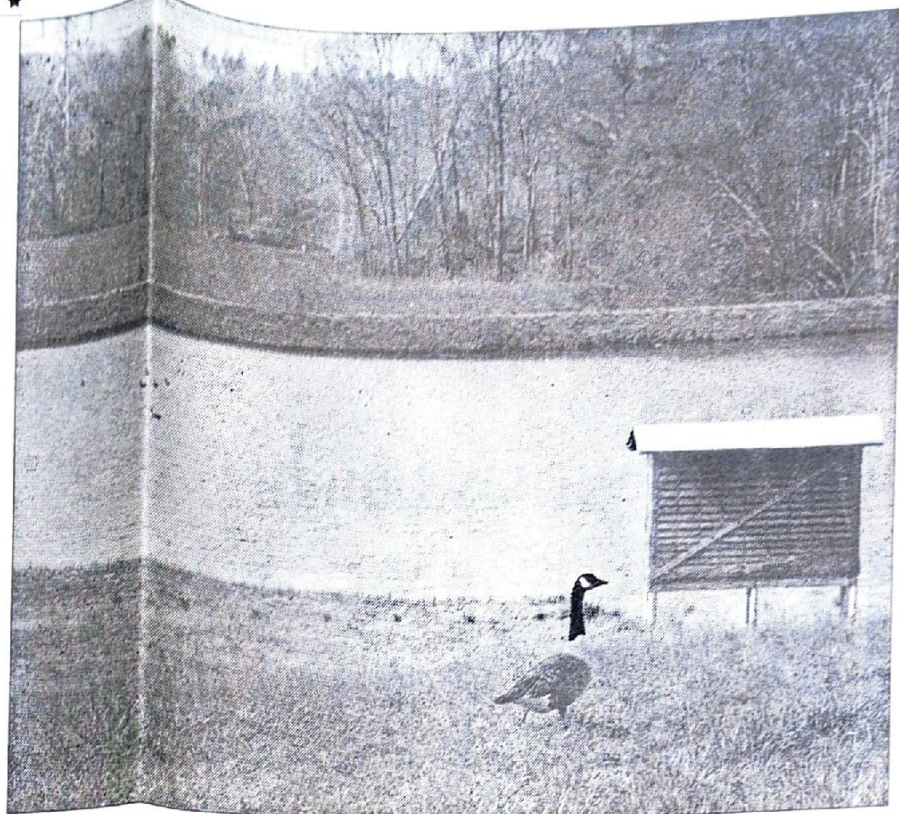
Weston said he has not talked with Allison about the idea, but the county may ask Catawba Waterfowl Inc. to continue operating the refuge. "Those people have given their life's blood to that place."

Eventually, the waterfowl refuge could be connected to Latta Plantation Park if the county also buys Rural Hill, a nearby historic property, and other waterfront parcels, Weston said.

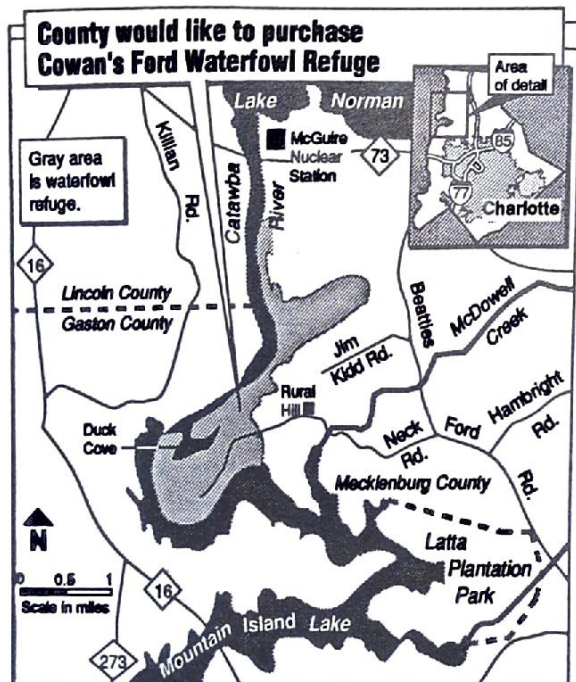
He may approach the Audubon Society or the Carolina Raptor Center about operating an environmental center in the area, Weston said.

Want to go?

If you're interested in visiting the Cowan's Ford Waterfowl Refuge, take Beatties Ford Road north from Charlotte to Neck Road. The refuge is on a gravel road that picks up where Neck Road ends.



TOM FRANKLIN/Staff



SOURCE: Mecklenburg County Park and Recreation Dept.

MIKE FISHER/Staff